

Area of Study 4A – Mark’s Gospel

Overview

The textual studies section for Christianity refers specifically to the Gospel of Mark.

There are two sections: Who is Jesus?; The Nature of Discipleship.

The themes and teachings of this Gospel are explored in depth; the references within the specification should be used as a starting point in a student’s textual studies and students may use other texts from the Bible to help contextualise, understand and compare the teachings found below.

Students will be expected to study Christianity and Mark’s Gospel within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should recognise that Christianity is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Judaism, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast the areas of belief and practice within Christianity with non-religious views.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Christians today should be explored throughout the two sections. They should understand how varied interpretations of the meaning of passages from Mark’s Gospel may give rise to diversity within Christian traditions and consider how far Christian and non-religious communities give authority to Mark’s Gospel, especially in relation to other sources of contemporary authority.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The Messiah and the Son of Man: the expectations of the Messiah at the time of Jesus based on the Old Testament; (Isaiah 53) what the use of these titles shows about Jesus; the title 'Son of Man'; the meaning of the title, including reference to Daniel 7:13, its use in Mark's Gospel and what it shows about Jesus; the significance of Jesus as Messiah and Son of Man for different Christians today.
1.2	The baptism of Jesus (Mark 1:2–11): the events of the baptism; divergent understandings of its significance, including marking the beginning of the ministry of Jesus, what it shows about him, and its significance for Christians today.
1.3	Nature miracles in Mark's Gospel: what they show about Jesus, including the calming of the storm (Mark 4:35–41); the feeding of the five thousand (Mark 6:32–44) and the walking on the water (Mark 6:45–52) and divergent understandings of their significance for different Christians today; Christian responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) which maintain that miracles can be scientifically explained and provide no proof of Jesus as divine.
1.4	The healing miracles in Mark's Gospel: what they show about Jesus, including the healing of Legion (Mark 5:1–20); the raising of Jairus' daughter (Mark 5:21–43) and divergent understandings of their significance for Christians today.
1.5	Peter's confession at Caesarea Philippi (Mark 8:27–33): what this shows about Jesus and his purpose; ideas about the Messianic secret in Mark's Gospel.
1.6	The transfiguration (Mark 9:1–10): what this event shows about Jesus; the reasons and importance of the appearance of Moses and Elias in relation to Moses' role as lawgiver and the Old Testament prophecy of Elias; divergent understandings of its significance for Christians today; Christian responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) which maintain that visions, such as the transfiguration, provide no proof that Jesus is the Messiah.
1.7	The conflicts of Jesus in Mark's Gospel: the healing of the paralysed man (Mark 2:1–12); disagreements about the Sabbath (Mark 2:23–3:6) and their link with Old Testament understandings of the Sabbath; and the cleansing of the Temple (Mark 11:15–18), what these show about Jesus and why they might be important in the narrative of Mark's Gospel.
1.8	The last days of Jesus' life: reasons for his arrest; the Last Supper (Mark 14:12–31); the prayers in Gethsemane (Mark 14:32–42); the betrayal and arrest (Mark 14:43–52); the trial before the High Priest (Mark 14:53–65); the trial before Pilate (Mark 15:1–15); the Passion (Mark 15:21–39; 16:1–8), what these events show about the purpose of Jesus' life, and how they may differ from other Gospel accounts, what these events show about Jesus; divergent understandings of the significance of these events for different Christians today.